Lesson 03: Pronunciation: Vowels

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 1: People and Places

Adapted from Speaking, Listening and Pronunciation Projects for ELLs - Intermediate Level by Brittany Zemlick, Grossmont College (CC BY 4.0): 1.5: Vowels.

In this lesson

You will review the five vowel letters and their long and short sounds. Then you will practice two pairs of vowel sounds that are easy to mix up: /ɪ/ as in "ship" and /iː/ as in "sheep", and /e/ as in "bed" and /æ/ as in "bad". You will listen, repeat, record yourself, and find the sounds in the Berlin video.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Give an example of a long and a short sound for each vowel letter.
- Explain what a minimal pair is.
- Hear and say the difference between /ɪ/ and /iː/.
- Hear and say the difference between /e/ and /æ/.
- Find these sounds in real English and say how they are spelled.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
minimal pair	two words that are different in only one sound	ship / sheep
/ɪ/ as in "ship"	a short sound; the lips are not stretched	pill, fit, hill
/iː/ as in "sheep"	a long sound; smile and stretch your lips	peel, feet, heel
/e/ as in "bed"	open your mouth a little	said, men, left
/æ/ as in "bad"	drop your jaw a little	sad, man, laughed
mitt	a glove for catching a baseball	Is that your mitt?
peel	the skin of a fruit	an orange peel
heel	the back part of a shoe	a shoe with a high heel

Rules and explanations

Vowels and minimal pairs

- There are 5 vowel letters in English: A, E, I, O and U. Each vowel has a long sound and a short sound.

- Sometimes two vowel sounds are hard to hear apart: "ship" and "sheep" may sound the same to you.
- "ship" and "sheep" are a **minimal pair**: only one sound is different. If you say the wrong sound, you say a different word.

/ɪ/ as in "ship" and /iː/ as in "sheep"

- **/ɪ/:** Open your mouth a little. Do not stretch the sides of your lips out. Make the sound in your throat.
- **/iː/:** Open your mouth a little. Smile: stretch the sides of your lips out as far as you can. Make the sound in your throat.

List 1: /ɪ/	List 1: /iː/	List 2: /ɪ/	List 2: /iː/
pill	peel	fill	feel
mitt	meat	ship	sheep
fit	feet	lip	leap
lick	leak	hit	heat
hill	heel	bin	bean
chick	cheek	live	leave
it	eat	slip	sleep
		Tim	team

/e/ as in "bed" and /æ/ as in "bad"

- **/e/** as in "tent": Relax and open your mouth a little. Stretch the sides of your mouth out just a little more than for /ɪ/. Make the sound in your throat.
- **/æ/** as in "camp": Relax and open your mouth a little. Drop your jaw slightly. Make the sound in your throat.

/e/	bed	said	set	celery	men	mess	left
/æ/	bad	sad	sat	salary	man	mass	laughed

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Standard Arabic has only three vowel qualities (a, i, u), each short or long. English has many more vowel sounds, so pairs like /e/ and /æ/, or /ɪ/ and /e/, may sound the same to you at first. - In Arabic, a long and a short "i" differ mainly in length. In English, /iː/ and /ɪ/ also differ in mouth shape: smile for /iː/, relax your lips for /ɪ/.

Practice

The audio clips are in the attachments folder for 1.5 Vowels on your computer (folder "01.05-vowels"), or on the original web page. Play the file named in each exercise.

1. Vowel quiz. Watch the Scratch Garden video "Vowel Sounds" (link below). Then answer: a) How many vowels are in the English alphabet? (2 / 5 / 26 / 10) b) How many sounds does each vowel have? (2 / 5 / 26 / 10) c) The five vowels in English are A, E, I, ____ and ____. d) Each vowel has a long sound and a _____ sound. e) Which word has the short sound, and which has the long sound? apple / acorn; elephant / eagle; insect / island; ostrich / oatmeal; umbrella / unicorn

2. Tongue twister. The book's pictures show a sheep, a ship, a man slipping on a banana, and a road covered in sleet (icy rain). Say *The sheep on the ship slipped on the sheet of sleet*. 3 times quickly and record yourself. What do you notice about the sounds in sheep, ship, slip, sheet and sleet?

3. Listen: /ɪ/ and /iː/. a) Play "Vowel_Sounds_Ship_and_Sheep" and repeat the words in List 1. b) Same or different? Play "Ship_and_Ship_Listening_Practice_1". You hear two words from List 1. Write S (same) or D (different) for 1–8. Example: "pill... peel" = D. c) Which word? Play "Vowel_Sounds_Ship_and_Sheep_Listening_Practice_2". Write the word you hear: 1 pill / peel; 2 mitt / meat; 3 fit / feet; 4 lick / leak; 5 hill / heel; 6 it / eat; 7 chick / cheek d) List 2 has no clip to repeat, so ask your tutor to say the words and repeat them. Then play "Ship_and_Ship_Listening_Practice_3" (S or D for 1–8) and "Ship_and_sheep_listneing_practice_4" (write the word you hear from each pair in List 2, 1–8).

4. With your tutor (instead of pair work). Say one word from each pair and ask the tutor which word it heard. Then play the book's game: the tutor reads words from both lists in a mixed order; raise your left hand for /ɪ/, your right hand for /iː/.

5. Sentence a or b? Play "Ship_and_Sheep_listening_practice_5" and use the table "Listening Practice 5" in your printed lesson (six pairs of sentences). Which sentence do you hear? Mark the correct reply. Then read the sentences to your tutor and practice: the tutor says sentence a or b, and you give the correct reply. Finally, record all 12 sentences with their replies, listen, and record again.

6. Notice /ɪ/ and /iː/ in real English. Watch "25 Things to do in Berlin" with the CC (subtitles) button on. Find at least 3 words with /ɪ/ and 3 words with /iː/. How do you spell each sound?

7. /e/ and /æ/ in sentences. The book shows tents at a campsite and a lamp in the dark. Read: *The man met his friend by the tents at the camp. "I can't see," said the man. But the friend didn't let him light the lamp*. Underline the /e/ and /æ/ sounds. Then say the sentences slowly and clearly.

8. Listen: /e/ and /æ/. a) Play "Bed_and_bad_vowel_sounds" and repeat the words in the /e/ and /æ/ table. b) Play "Bed_Bad_practice_1". Write S or D for 1–7. c) Play "Bed_and_bad_listening_practice_2". Write the word you hear: 1 bed / bad; 2 said / sad; 3 set / sat; 4 celery / salary; 5 men / man; 6 mess / mass; 7 left / laughed d) Do exercise 4 again with these words.

9. Sentence a or b? Play "Bed_and_bad_practice_3" and use the /e/ and /æ/ table "Listening Practice 3" in your printed lesson. Mark the correct reply. Practice with your tutor as in exercise 5, then record all 8 sentences and replies.

10. Notice /e/ and /æ/ in real English. Watch the Berlin video again with CC on. Find at least 3 words with /e/ and 3 with /æ/. How do you spell each sound? Why can you hear the /æ/ sound in "can't" but not in "can"? (We can't come to the party. / We can come to the party.)

Speak with your tutor

- "I will say one word from each pair: pill or peel, fit or feet, live or leave. Tell me which word you heard."
- "I will read you the ship and sheep sentences from my lesson. Then say sentence a or b, and I will give the correct reply."
- "Ask me 'Can you...?' questions about my skills. I will answer 'Yes, I can' or 'No, I can't'. Tell me if 'can' and 'can't' sound different."
- "Listen to me say the tongue twister three times. Tell me if 'sheep' and 'ship' sound different."

Read aloud

1. The sheep on the ship slipped on the sheet of sleet. (↘)
2. Did you feel the pot? (↗)
3. She wants to leave here. (↘)
4. Is that an orange peel? (↗)
5. Is that Dad? (↗)
6. They laughed. (↘)
7. We can come to the party. (↘)
8. We can't come to the party. (↘)

Watch online

- Scratch Garden, Vowel Sounds: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4TjcT7Gto3U
- 25 Things to do in Berlin (turn on CC subtitles): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lw5NHQeXzpA

Answer key

1. (book) a) 5 b) 2 c) O, U d) short e) short: apple, elephant, insect, ostrich, umbrella; long: acorn, eagle, island, oatmeal, unicorn
2. Sheep, sheet and sleet have the long /iː/ sound. Ship and slip(ped) have the short /ɪ/ sound.
3. (book) b) 1 S; 2 D (mitt–meat); 3 D (fit–feet); 4 S; 5 S; 6 D (chick–cheek); 7 D (it–eat); 8 S. c) 1 pill; 2 meat; 3 feet; 4 lick; 5 heel; 6 it; 7 cheek. d) Practice 3: 1 S; 2 S; 3 D (lip–leap); 4 S; 5 S; 6 D (leave–live); 7 D (slip–sleep); 8 S. Practice 4: 1 feel; 2 sheep; 3 lip; 4 hit; 5 bin; 6 leave; 7 sleep; 8 Tim
4. Your tutor checks.
5. (book) You hear 1a (feel), 2a (live), 3a (sleep), 4a (mitt), 5b (peel), 6a (hill). The first reply in each number goes with a and the second with b, so the correct reply is always the first one, except in number 5 (Yes, I had fruit salad for breakfast).
6. (book: some possible answers) /ɪ/: city, with, list, symbol, vintage, biggest, hipster, music. /iː/: we, East, between, freedom, green, street, eat, people, and the y in "city". Spelling: /ɪ/ is usually "i", sometimes "y" (symbol). /iː/ can be "ee" (green), "ea" (eat), "e" (we), "y" (city), "i" (graffiti) or "eo" (people).
7. /e/: met, friend, tents, said, friend, let. /æ/: man, camp, can't, man, lamp. ("at" also has /æ/ when you say it slowly, but in fast speech it is usually weak.)
8. (book) b) 1 S; 2 D (said–sad); 3 S; 4 D (celery–salary); 5 S; 6 S; 7 D (left–laughed). c) 1 bad; 2 said; 3 set; 4 salary; 5 men; 6 mass; 7 laughed
9. (book) You hear 1a (dead), 2a (mess), 3b (laughed), 4a (man). The correct reply is the first one, except in number 3 (I don't think it was very funny).
10. (book: some possible answers) /e/: spend, best, West, center, every, head, ketchup. /æ/: had, and, after, Jackson, actually, animals, can't, fast, snack. Spelling: /e/ is usually "e", sometimes "ea" (head) or "ai" (said). /æ/ is usually "a" ("au" in laughed). "Can" is usually not stressed in a sentence, so its vowel becomes a short schwa /ə/ as in "about". "Can't" is stressed, so you hear the full /æ/.

My notes